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In early April, Kolkata-based cocktail bar AMPM organised a Spring Tea Trail aimed at showcasing the rich cultural heritage of the Himalayan region around North Bengal and crafting a foraging experience to curate a cocktail event at 4,800 ft above sea level. The team, along with a few guests, had the opportunity to visit the Glenburn Tea Estate in Darjeeling, where, under the able guidance of the Bacardi team, they learnt the art of infusing gin with various herbs, spices, and tea to create unique and flavourful cocktails. Back home in Kolkata, the bar launched a menu with four cocktails inspired by the trip.

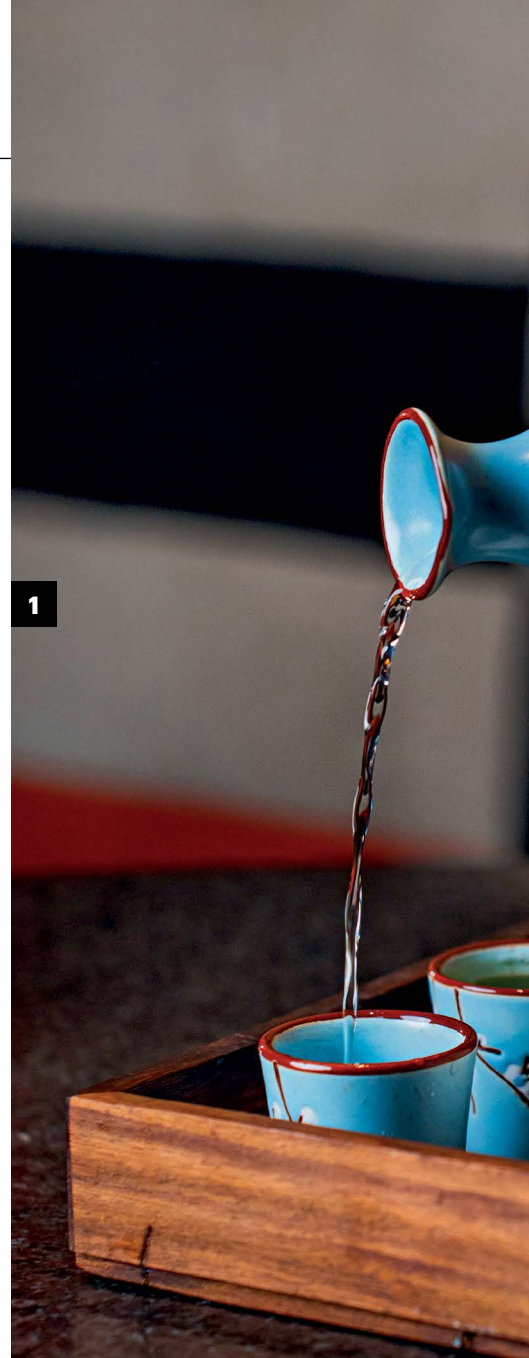
Tea can add complexity to a cocktail in a way that only a few other ingredients can. From green, oolong, and black tea to chai and other blends, these cocktails use myriad styles to delicious effect. While the AMPM menu uses Bombay Sapphire gin infused with Darjeeling second flush, green tea, and strawberry black tea (all from the Glenburn Tea Estate), bars across the country are using various teas—from delicate floral notes to robust herbal flavours—to create an unforgettable journey in the art of infusions and mixology.

So, if, like the Mad Hatter in *Alice in Wonderland*, you believe that “it’s always tea time,” these cocktails are meant just for you. Take, for example, the Highland Tea cocktail at Lupa in Bengaluru, which mixes Earl Grey Tea with whisky. “Whisky makes the pairing come alive for the more complex

undertones of tea. Bitterness and astringency are counterbalanced with an acid and a hint of sweetness, making both flavours harmoniously sing,” says chef Manu Chandra, Founder of Lupa. “I’ve always found the flavour profiles in tea fascinating; they add depth, character, and a balancing act to modern cocktails,” he adds.

The conceptualisation of tea-based cocktails likely evolved from a blend of historical influences and contemporary creativity. Tea was commonly used in punches and other mixed drinks during the 18-19th centuries. As cocktail culture developed over time, bartenders began incorporating tea into contemporary recipes. “As people became more health-conscious, there was a growing demand for lighter and more natural drink options. Tea became a popular choice among those seeking beverages that were both flavourful and healthy, making tea-based cocktails a popular and trendy option in bars worldwide,” says Surendra Singh, Beverage Manager, Raffles Udaipur. The hotel’s famous Writers Bar is known for its signature Raffles Blend, a black autumn tea from the Manjhee Valley estate. This tea is infused with marigold,

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